Neal T. Gillespie

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Hiring Committee
Allen Public Library
300 N. Allen Drive
Allen, TX 75013

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Specialist position at the Allen Public Library. I hold a B.A. from Chapman University, which is the education your posting asks for, and I have spent the last few years doing a version of this job outside a library. I look after a physical collection, I cataloged it myself, and I built the system my organization uses to search it.

My title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, and the collection I look after is the organization's archive of everything it has printed and mailed. Some of it went out to the entire donor file. Some of it was a single proposal prepared for one major donor. A sample of every piece comes back from the printer and I am the one who takes it in. I label what arrives and shelve it by campaign and mail code, I keep the shelves accurate as the collection grows, and I pull a past piece whenever a writer or a director needs something to work from.

The duty I am most drawn to is recommending books, authors and reference material to patrons, and it is the one I have put the most of my own time into. I founded the Free Knowledge Library, a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum, where I designed the site, the database behind it and the classification scheme, and built the catalog that readers search. Working out how a collection should be arranged so that somebody who does not already know what they want can still find their way into it is the whole problem of readers advisory, and I have spent a long time on it.

I did the same thing at work for a collection nobody could search. When I inherited the archive, finding anything in it meant already knowing where it was. I designed a SQL database for it and defined a consistent record for every piece, so that a mail code or a campaign name would be enough to locate something, then worked back through several campaign years and cataloged the existing material against that standard. On top of the database I built a searchable reading room, which lets anyone in the department find a piece and see where the physical original sits on the shelf. I also developed statetrack.net, which publishes state campaign finance records for state house and state senate candidates in all fifty states.

I am comfortable carrying a desk alone. At Chapman University's Fowler School of Law I staffed the registrar service window as the front-line contact. I handled opening and closing, including the transaction records, and I explained procedures that were not obvious to students who had no reason to know them. I processed more than five hundred transcripts and exam records as well, accurately and in confidence.

Before my current role I was Development Manager at the University of Austin, where part of my work was the campus library. The university was building that library largely from donated books, and I took the donations in and documented them. One of those gifts was a complete *Harvard Classics* set, which I handled from the first conversation with the donor through to the books being shelved. I gave them a tour of the library in person and kept them updated on where the set had ended up. I led visitor tours more generally as well.

It is worth saying why somebody with my background is applying for a part-time specialist role. I begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, and I have already started the ALA's Library Support Staff Certification, with a master's in library and information science to follow. Working in a library while I study is worth a good deal more to me than the hours suggest, because it is the practical experience the coursework assumes you are getting somewhere, and I would rather build it behind a desk than only on paper.

The posted schedule, including both weekend afternoons and a Thursday evening, works for me. I should say plainly that I am able to relocate. I am in Austin now, and I am willing to move anywhere in Texas a position requires.

Thank you for your consideration. I would welcome the chance to talk about the role.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie